

| By Shafi Rahman |

On his first day as Speaker of the 14th Lok Sabha on June 4, 2004, Somnath Chatterjee waxed eloquent about parliamentary democracy and the heavy responsibilities that elected members of Parliament have to shoulder. "We should ask ourselves when

the House rises for the day every evening as to what we have done during the day for the country and for the people and whether we have justified the people's faith in sending us here. Nothing will give us more satisfaction than the feeling that we have tried and done our best." Said in all good faith, Chatterjee's words have rarely been translated into deeds by the MPs during the last four-and-a-half years. As the 14th Lok Sabha enters its last stretch, there is evidence that a large number of MPs treat their's as a part-time job. Many MPs don't attend the House for days together; the clever ones sign the attendance register and slip out, ensuring that they don't miss out on their daily allowance even if they miss crucial debates. Many others feel the prick of conscience and turn up in the House and do nothing; 32 MPs are still observing a vow of silence, waiting to participate in their maiden debate; 37 MPs are yet to table a question. Many more take their seats in the august house just to add to the decibel levels without contributing in any way to debates or discussions.

But mercifully, as in all previous Lok Sabhas, there are a handful on the Treasury and the Opposition benches who add verve and dignity to debate. But alarmingly, it is the

numbers of the non-serious that is going up. Considering that every minute of Parliamentary session costs the country Rs 23,083, we are led to believe that democracy comes with a high price tag. Consider this zero hour tiff between Speaker Chatterjee and a CPI(M) MP from Kerala during a debate on rail safety:

MP: Respected Speaker Sir. Of late, the railways have discontinued the supply of South Indian food items.

Speaker: You want to know about food items on Indian Railways?

MP: Yes Sir. It is a very serious issue.

Speaker: You should pose a question on safety in Indian Railways. I am sorry, I cannot allow this.

(Interruptions)

Speaker: In spite of my weakness for gastronomy, I cannot allow you.

(Interruptions)

Speaker: Ask about railway safety?

(Interruptions)

Speaker: I am sorry, I won't let you make a mockery of this House.

Over the last few years, such exchanges have become the norm rather than the exception. Despite the Speaker's best efforts, parliamentary business has been punctuated more by inanities than informed debate, deadlock than discussion. That is, when it meets. The 14th Lok Sabha

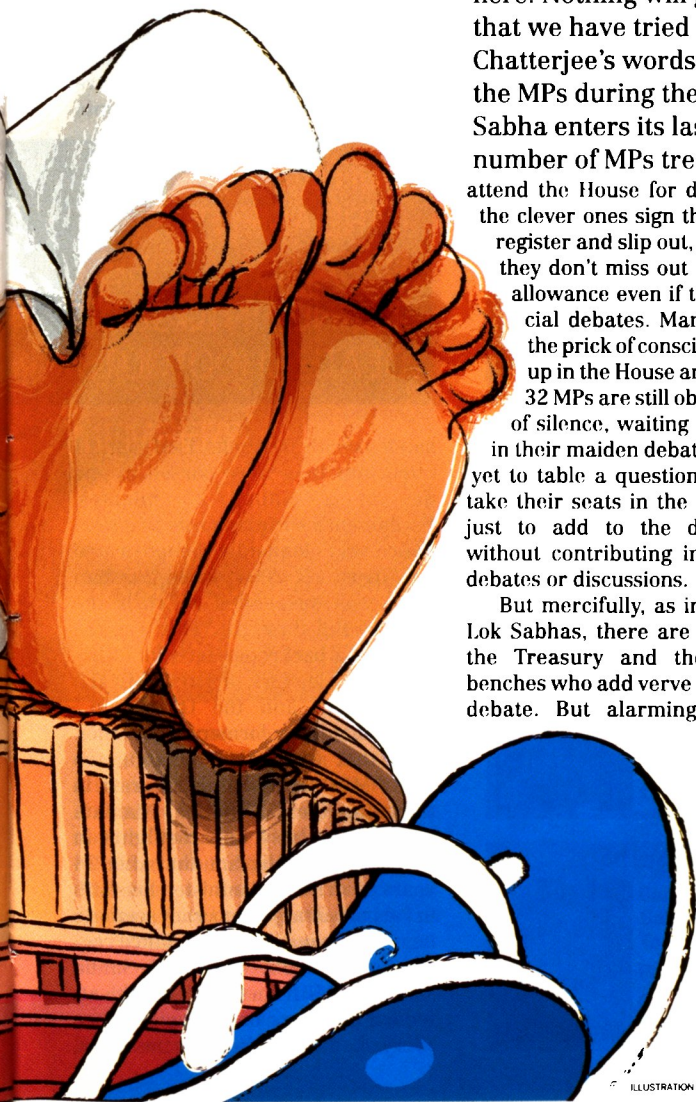


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